

- RAG Learning

2.6 Ecologism

Politics — Edexcel (9PL0) — Component 2: Non-core Political Ideas, Section B

Exam Tip: This is one of **five** non-core ideas. You sit **one** of Anarchism, Ecologism, Feminism, Multiculturalism or Nationalism, answering a single 24-mark "To what extent" question (AO1 8 / AO2 8 / AO3 8). Learn your chosen idea properly rather than all five thinly.

Ecologism is a reaction against industrialisation and urbanisation. Its distinctive move — and the thing that makes it examinable — is that it questions the **anthropocentrism** that liberalism, conservatism and socialism all share. No other ideology on the specification asks whether human beings should be the measure of political value.

Ecologism — a political ideology placing the relationship between humanity and nature at the centre of analysis.

Ecocentrism — the ecosystem, not humanity, is the centre of moral concern; nature has intrinsic value.

Anthropocentrism — nature is valuable chiefly as a resource serving human purposes.

Holism — the whole is more than the sum of its parts and must be understood as a whole.

Deep ecology — ecocentric; requires a change of consciousness and a restructuring of society.

Shallow ecology — anthropocentric; protects the environment for human benefit through reform.

Social ecology — Bookchin's view that ecological breakdown originates in social hierarchy.

Ecofeminism — the domination of nature and of women arise from the same hierarchical thinking.

Sustainability — resource use that does not exceed the capacity of natural systems to renew.

Tragedy of the commons — depletion of a shared resource by individuals acting in their

own rational interest.

Post-materialism — once material security is achieved, quality-of-life values gain weight.

1. Core ideas and principles

Principle	What it means
Ecology	Humanity is part of an interdependent natural system, not its owner or its exception
Holism	Systems must be understood whole; intervening in one part produces consequences elsewhere that studying the part cannot predict
Environmental ethics	Extending moral consideration beyond present humans — to future generations, other species, ecosystems
Materialism and consumerism	Industrial society equates wellbeing with consumption, which drives damage while failing to deliver satisfaction
Sustainability	Resource use within the capacity of natural systems; growth without limit is physically impossible
Post-materialism	Explains why green politics emerged in affluent societies after material security was widely achieved

The critique of industrialism

The most distinctive ecological argument, because it cuts across the ownership question that divides every other ideology. Capitalism and state socialism share a commitment to nature as a resource for limitless growth, and both delivered industrialisation with comparable environmental consequences. The ecological objection is therefore not to *who owns* production but to *what production is for* — which is why ecologism sits awkwardly on the conventional left–right spectrum.

2. Deep, shallow and social ecology

	Deep ecology	Shallow ecology	Social ecology
Values	Ecocentric — nature has intrinsic value	Anthropocentric — nature protected for human benefit	Ecocentric, but the analysis is social
Diagnosis	A worldview treating nature as resource; materialism and industrialism	Pollution, emissions, resource management	Hierarchy within human society
Prescription	Changed consciousness; radical restructuring to human scale	Regulation, taxation, technology, international agreement	Abolition of hierarchy; decentralised direct democracy
Politics	Not readily compatible with any existing programme	Compatible with mainstream party politics	Draws on the anarchist tradition

The strands of social ecology on the spec are **eco-socialism** (the crisis is caused by capitalist accumulation), **eco-anarchism** (by hierarchy) and **ecofeminism** (by patriarchy). Each combines ecological premises with a prior analysis of domination — which is the key point for the "is ecologism a distinct ideology" question.

3. Key thinkers

Aldo Leopold (1887–1948) — *A Sand County Almanac* (1949). The **land ethic**: the boundaries of the moral community should be enlarged to include "soils, waters, plants, and animals, or collectively: the land". A thing is right when it tends to preserve the integrity, stability and beauty of the biotic community. Humanity changes from conqueror of the land-community to plain member and citizen of it.

Rachel Carson (1907–64) — *Silent Spring* (1962). Documented how pesticides, notably DDT, accumulate through food chains and affect species far from the intended target. Its importance is both scientific and political: it demonstrated **holism** empirically, and it is generally credited with launching the modern environmental movement and with the eventual banning of DDT.

E. F. Schumacher (1911–77) — *Small Is Beautiful* (1973). Production should be **human-scale** and appropriate to its setting; "intermediate technology" rather than the largest available. His decisive economic argument: natural resources are **capital, not income**, so an economy consuming them without replacement is liquidating a stock while recording it as production. Also argued for "Buddhist economics" — maximising wellbeing with minimum consumption rather than maximising consumption.

Murray Bookchin (1921–2006) — **social ecology**. Ecological breakdown originates in **hierarchical structures within human society**: the domination of nature follows from and reproduces the domination of humans by other humans. The remedy is the abolition of hierarchy through decentralised, directly democratic communities organised confederally. He attacked deep ecology for blaming humanity in general, which identifies nobody who benefits from ecological destruction and nobody who could change it — and which he argued slides towards misanthropy.

Carolyn Merchant (1936–) — *The Death of Nature* (1980). **Ecofeminism**. The Scientific Revolution replaced an organic conception of nature as a nurturing mother with a mechanistic one in which nature is inert matter to be mastered — and the same dualistic thinking that set culture above nature set men above women. The domination of nature and of women therefore share a root, and neither can be addressed alone.

4. Ecologism on the state, the economy, society and human nature

	Position	Internal disagreement
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The state	Existing states are organised around growth and are part of the problem	Reform through the state (shallow) against decentralisation or its abolition (deep, social)
The economy	Growth cannot continue indefinitely on a finite planet	Green growth and decoupling against steady-state or degrowth economics
Society	Human-scale, decentralised communities aligned with local ecological limits	How radical the restructuring must be
Human nature	Capable of living within limits; current behaviour is shaped by industrial society	Whether the change required is of consciousness (deep) or of social structure (social)

5. Evaluation

Is ecologism a distinct ideology?

Yes	No
Supplies a complete worldview: an account of humanity's place in nature, a critique of industrialism, and a prescription	Most strands attach to a prior analysis of domination — capital, hierarchy, patriarchy
Holism and ecocentrism genuinely break with the anthropocentrism every other ideology shares	Only deep ecology is free-standing, and it has the least developed political programme
Generates conclusions no other tradition reaches — rejecting growth, including future generations and other species	Resembles nationalism: a cross-cutting set of premises needing a social analysis to generate politics
Has its own internal factions, which indicates real content	The shape of those factions is precisely what cuts against independence

Is sustainable growth achievable?

For: ecological modernisation argues output can rise while resource use and emissions fall, through efficiency, renewables and circular production. Several developed economies have recorded absolute emissions reductions alongside growth. It is also the only politically viable position — no electorate has voted for reduced material living standards.

Against: growth compounds, so decoupling must run indefinitely *faster* than growth itself. Recorded decoupling is partly an artefact of measurement, since emissions attributed to production fall when manufacturing relocates; consumption-based accounting shows far less improvement. Jevons' paradox observes that efficiency gains lower costs and so increase total consumption.

Judgement: the strand with the better argument has the weaker programme, and the strand with the viable programme has the weaker argument. That gap explains the shape ecological politics has taken.

Exam Tip: The Bookchin–deep ecology dispute is the most productive AO2 material here, because both sides have a real point: Bookchin identifies who benefits and what must change, but risks reducing ecologism to a pre-existing critique of hierarchy; deep ecology preserves what is distinctive about ecologism but cannot say who should act. Use it to answer "to what extent do ecologists agree" without simply listing strands.

Quick recall

- Core: ecology, holism, environmental ethics, critique of materialism, sustainability, post-materialism
- Deep (ecocentric, consciousness) · shallow (anthropocentric, reform) · social (hierarchy)
- Strands of social ecology: eco-socialism, eco-anarchism, ecofeminism
- Leopold: the land ethic — humanity as plain member of the biotic community
- Carson: *Silent Spring*, DDT, holism demonstrated empirically
- Schumacher: small is beautiful; resources are capital, not income
- Bookchin: hierarchy is the cause; attacks deep ecology for blaming humanity in general

- Merchant: the mechanistic worldview links the domination of nature and of women
- The critique of industrialism cuts across left and right — the ownership question is not the issue